

Gamma Serpentis
3 SunsEta Serpentis
15 Suns

SERPENS

THE SERPENT

UNIQUELY AMONG THE CONSTELLATIONS, SERPENS IS DIVIDED IN TWO, WITH ITS HEAD ON ONE SIDE OF OPHIUCHUS AND ITS TAIL ON THE OTHER. THE TWO PARTS COUNT AS A SINGLE CONSTELLATION.

Serpens represents a snake or serpent held by Ophiuchus, who grasps its head in his left hand and its tail in his right. The head section of the constellation is known as Serpens Caput, while the tail is Serpens Cauda.

The constellation's brightest star is 3rd-magnitude Alpha Serpentis. Its popular name, Unukalhai, is from the Arabic for "serpent's neck," which is where it lies. In the serpent's head is Beta Serpentis, which has a 7th-magnitude unrelated companion visible with binoculars. In the serpent's tail is M16, a star cluster surrounded by the Eagle Nebula, made famous by the "pillars of creation" Hubble image. Also in the tail, Alya (Theta Serpentis) is a 5th-magnitude double divisible through a small telescope. Nearby is IC 4765, an open cluster visible through binoculars.

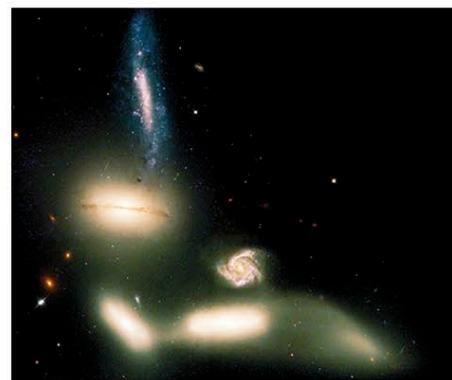
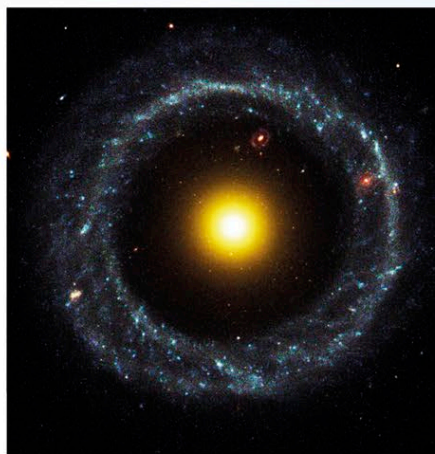


◁ Pillars of Creation

This iconic image taken by the Hubble Space telescope shows columns of gas and dust in the Eagle Nebula. About 4 light-years tall, the pillars are a site of new star formation. At the same time, they are also being eroded by ultraviolet light from other hot, newborn stars nearby.

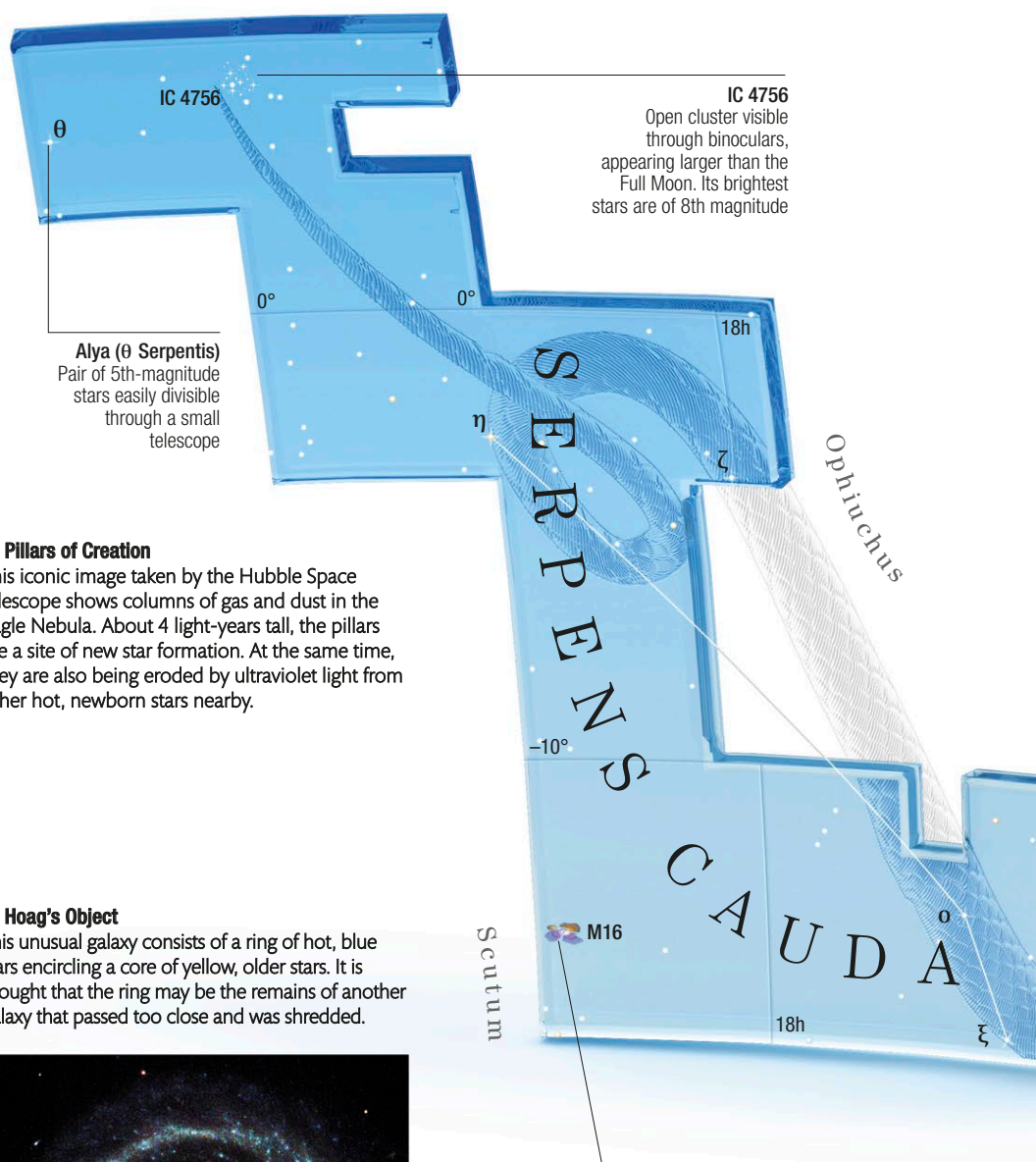
▽ Hoag's Object

This unusual galaxy consists of a ring of hot, blue stars encircling a core of yellow, older stars. It is thought that the ring may be the remains of another galaxy that passed too close and was shredded.



◁ Seyfert's Sextet

A group of galaxies that consists of four interacting galaxies and two other members. The small spiral at the center of this image from the Hubble Space Telescope is not part of the interaction but a background object in the same line of sight by chance. The sixth member is not a galaxy at all but a long tail of stars torn from one of the galaxies.



IC 4756

IC 4756
Open cluster visible through binoculars, appearing larger than the Full Moon. Its brightest stars are of 8th magnitude

Alfa (θ Serpentis)
Pair of 5th-magnitude stars easily divisible through a small telescope

18h

Ophiuchus

-10°

M16

CAUDA

18h

M16

Open cluster visible through binoculars and small telescopes; appears hazy because it is embedded in the Eagle Nebula